

Policy and Blame Attribution: Citizens' Preferences, Policy Reputations, and Policy Surprises

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Abstract Negativity bias suggests that the attribution of blame to governments, for alleged or actual policy failures, is disproportionately pertinent for their popularity. However, when citizens attribute blame for adverse consequences of a policy, does it make a difference which policy was it, and who was the political agent that adopted the policy? We posit that the level of blame citizens attribute to political agents for policy failures depends on three policy-oriented considerations: (1) the distance between a citizen's ideal policy and the agent's *established policy position*; (2) the distance between a citizen's ideal policy and the agent's *concrete policy choice*; and (3) the distance between the agent's established policy position and her concrete policy choice. The inherent relationship between these three policy-oriented considerations renders their integration in one model a theoretical and methodological imperative. The model provides novel observable predictions regarding the conditions under which each of the three policy-oriented factors will produce either pronounced or subtle observable effects on blame attribution. We test the model's predictions in two survey experiments, in Israel and in Germany. The results of both experiments are highly consistent with the model's predictions. These findings offer an important contribution by specifying the ways in which individual-level preferences interact with politicians' policy reputations and policy choices to shape blame attribution. Our model entails unintuitive revisions to

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several strands of the literature, and in the “[Discussion](#)” section we provide tentative support for the applicability of this model to other political judgments beyond blame attribution.

Keywords Blame attribution · Policy preferences · Policy reputation · Policy surprise · Nixon goes to China · Experiment

Introduction

Attribution of responsibility to political agents is at the heart of democratic political life. Such judgments motivate political behaviors as voting, protest, and civil disobedience, and the assumption that citizens are able to attribute responsibility soundly is fundamental to the notion of democratic governance. The general human tendency to give more weight to negative consequences (Kahneman and Tversky 1979), renders citizens more receptive to government failures than government successes (Soroka 2006). This regularity, known as negativity bias, suggests that the attribution of blame to governments, for alleged or actual policy failures, is disproportionately pertinent for their popularity (Hood 2010; Soroka 2014; Weaver 1986). However, when citizens attribute blame for adverse consequences of a policy, does it make a difference which policy was it, and who was the political agent that adopted the policy? More specifically, how do ex-ante policy preferences vis-à-vis the concrete policy, and the agent’s policy reputation interact to shape these political evaluations?

In order to address these questions we posit that the level of blame citizens attribute to political agents for policy failures depends on three policy-oriented considerations: (1) the distance between a citizen’s ideal policy and the agent’s *established policy position*; (2) the distance between a citizen’s ideal policy and the agent’s *concrete policy choice*; and (3) the distance between the agent’s established policy position and her concrete policy choice. The first factor refers to a citizen’s evaluation of an agent’s policy reputation. For example, most voters expect left-wing parties to be relatively more supportive of welfare programs. Is a voter who holds policy preferences that are relatively close to those that a left-wing party is expected to pursue (e.g. welfare state expansion) likely to attribute less blame to such a party when things go wrong, regardless of the specific policy that led to the failure? The second factor refers to a citizen’s evaluation of the specific policy that led to the failure. Is the welfare-state supporting voter mentioned above less likely to attribute blame for a policy failure caused by a welfare expanding policy, regardless of the agent who adopts it? Finally, the concrete policy choice may or may not be congruent with the responsible agent’s established policy position. Thus, the third policy-oriented factor relates to the congruence between the political agent’s policy reputation and her concrete policy choice. Going back to our pro-welfare voter, how much blame will she attribute to a social-democratic party that retrenches the welfare state?

The inherent relationship between the three policy-oriented considerations renders their integration in one model a theoretical and methodological imperative. The interactions among the three factors provide novel observable predictions regarding the conditions under which each of the three policy-oriented factors will produce either pronounced or subtle observable effects on blame attribution.

We test the model's predictions in two survey experiments, conducted in Israel and in Germany. While the two experiments vary in their ideological axes (hawk–dove vs. right–left), policy domain (security vs. labor policy), and the type of evaluated political agent (individual politicians vs. party coalitions), their results are highly consistent with the model's predictions. Furthermore, we employ mediation analysis to the German experiment's results in order to test the causal mechanism that underlies the model's observable results.

The findings of this paper offer an important contribution by specifying the ways in which individual-level preferences interact with politicians' policy reputations and policy choices to shape blame attribution. Our model entails unintuitive revisions to several strands of the literature, and in the “[Discussion](#)” section we provide tentative support for the applicability of this model of policy considerations to other political judgments beyond blame attribution (e.g. support).

Blame Attribution

Democratic theory is premised on the idea that elections are mechanisms of political accountability in which voters reward or punish incumbents and parties based on their performance (Fiorina 1981; Manin 1997; Powell 2000). Numerous studies of economic voting provide support for this simple reward-punishment model (C. Anderson 1995; Duch and Stevenson 2008; Lewis-Beck and Stegmaier 2000; Nannestad and Paldam 1994). However, performance is not the only factor that governs electoral choice. Apart from institutional arrangements, which affect the “clarity of responsibility” and thus moderate the impact of performance on political behavior (C. J. Anderson 2000; Hellwig and Samuels 2008; Powell and Whitten 1993), the literature suggests that, at the individual level, citizens' evaluations and judgments are moderated by political preferences, specifically partisanship (Lewis-Beck et al. 2008; Rudolph 2003b, 2006; Rudolph and Grant 2002; Tilley and Hobolt 2011).

In this study we go one step further and shed light on the role of policy-based considerations in shaping blame attribution. There are sound theoretical reasons to expect policy to be important for assessing responsibility. First, the very nature of responsibility judgments in general involves joint evaluations of an agent's identity *and* behavior (i.e. policy-making) (Rudolph 2006; Schlenker et al. 1994). Second, responsibility in general and blame in particular are attributed to political agents in response to specific *policy* choices and their subsequent outcomes. Additionally, while policy preferences were found to play an important role in the study of other political attitudes and behaviors (Adams et al. 2005; Downs 1957b; Duch et al. 2010; Kedar 2009), they have not yet been applied to the study of responsibility and blame attribution. A notable exception is the work of Rudolph (2003b) which found

that economic conservatives were less likely to attribute responsibility to the president, and more likely to attribute it to non-governmental actors. However, this finding pertains to the relationship between ideological preferences and the *overall* tendency to attribute responsibility to the government, while our attempt is to study how policy preferences affect the level of blame that is attributed to different political agents, depending on their policy reputation and the content of the concrete policy they adopt. In the following section we present our model of policy-based considerations in the formation of blame attribution.

A Policy-Based Model of Blame Attribution

Our theoretical point of departure draws on previous findings suggesting that responsibility attribution is a function of partisan identification (Rudolph 2003a, b, 2006; Rudolph and Grant 2002; Tilley and Hobolt 2011). Next, we introduce the first of three policy-based considerations—the ideological distance between a citizen and an agent’s established policy position. Equation 1 presents such a model:

$$Blame_i = \alpha|x_i - s| + \beta pid_i + \varepsilon_i \quad (1)$$

where $Blame_i$ represents the level of blame citizen i attributes to a political agent, such as a coalition party or an incumbent politician, x_i is i ’s placement on the ideological spectrum, and s is the established policy position of the agent on this spectrum, based on the agent’s long-term record. α is the parameter that represents the effect of citizen–agent ideological distance (henceforth “agent distance”— AD_i) on blame attribution.¹ pid_i is a dummy variable indicating whether voter i identifies with the agent’s party and β captures the party-identification effect. Finally, ε_i is a citizen specific random error term. The expected signs of α and β depend on the evaluation of the outcome for which responsibility is attributed. Drawing on the ‘selective attribution model’ (Tilley and Hobolt 2011), in cases of negative outcomes such as a policy failure, α will be positive, implying that citizens whose ideal points are farther away from the policy stance of the agent will attribute more blame for failures to that agent than citizens whose ideal points are closer to that long-term policy stance. Similarly, β will be negative, as party identifiers will attribute less blame for failures to the agent than non-identifiers.

The attribution of blame to a political agent typically pertains to a concrete policy choice on the part of the evaluated political agent. Thus, when modelling blame attribution, the distance between citizen i ’s ideal policy and that of the *concrete policy* pursued by the agent should be added to the baseline model. Equation 2 augments Eq. 1 by adding the distance between the citizen’s ideal position and that of policy cp , the political agent’s *concrete policy choice*, ($|x_i - cp|$), in the following form:

¹ The formal structure of this policy preferences relies on its implementation in spatial models of voting (Adams et al. 2005, p. 26; Downs 1957a); but such distances were also found to account for other political evaluations (e.g., Yair and Sulitzeanu-Kenan 2015).

$$Blame_i = \alpha|x_i - s| + \beta pid_i + \gamma|x_i - cp| + \varepsilon_i \quad (2)$$

where γ is the parameter that represents the effect of the citizen–concrete policy ideological distance (henceforth “concrete policy distance”— CPD_i) on blame attribution. The parameter γ is assumed to be positive, suggesting that the level of blame attributed for a policy failure is larger when the concrete policy that has led to the failure is perceived as less desirable by the citizen.² The two policy-related factors included in Eq. 2 differ in several ways. First, given that the *agent distance* aggregates past experiences, it is expected to elicit relatively stable policy expectations, while the *concrete policy distance* addresses a particular policy choice, which is likely to be more variable and transient in nature. Second, the *concrete policy distance* is based on more recent information, and is thus likely to carry more weight in the evaluation (Gerber and Green 1998).

The inclusion of a relatively stable established policy position and a concrete policy invite a further consideration, namely, the extent to which the two are congruent or surprising. Complementary insights in political economy and social psychology—the *Nixon-goes-to-China thesis*, and *blame validation*, respectively—provide the basis for our expectation that policy surprises—instances in which the concrete policy choice is at odds with the agent’s established policy reputation—play a role in the formation of blame attribution.

The ‘Nixon-goes-to-China’ thesis (hereafter: “NGC thesis”) is premised on the observation that sometimes a change in policy is brought about by elected officials from the party that is traditionally opposed to that change (Krueger 2000). Quite a number of such examples from the last 130 years have been identified in the literature (see Online Appendix 1), encompassing both the social–economic left–right axis (e.g., 1881 Bismarck, 1990s Blair), and the hawk–dove axis (e.g., 1941 Asquith, 1972 Nixon). Two asymmetric information based models (Cowen and Sutter 1998; Cukierman and Tommasi 1998) propose that these surprising policy initiatives involve political conditions that are favorable to the policy initiator. Assuming that incumbent politicians have superior information concerning the effects of policies compared to the electorate, if new information is obtained supporting a right-wing shift in policy, a left-wing politician can more credibly signal that the policy is an appropriate course of action than a right-wing politician because “voters will infer that the left-wing politician is motivated by objective facts, rather than his party’s natural ideological tendencies” (Krueger 2000, p. 129). The NGC thesis thus assumes that (1) politicians who adopt policies that are incongruent with their policy reputation are likely to enjoy a more favorable public reaction compared to comparable policies and policy-makers in congruent cases; and that (2) this effect is due to the assumption that under such seemingly surprising

² This expectation is consistent with the logic of spatial models in general and with several behavioral studies that have found such policy effects on positive attitudes such as support (Boudreau and MacKenzie 2014; Bullock 2011; Carsey and Layman 2006). Note, however, that all of these behavioral studies estimated the behavioral responses to *concrete policy information* and partisan identification, disregarding the established policy position of the political agent. Given the contribution of established policy positions of political agents (agent distance) to understanding political attitudes and behavior beyond the effect of partisan identification, we suspect that the partisan cue treatment effects estimated in these studies comprise both partisan identification and established policy position proximity.

policy changes, observers tend to infer that the policy motivation was to adequately respond to environmental constraints rather than to satisfy ideological preference. We later take advantage of this mediating role of inferred policy motivation in this theory to test the causal mechanism of this model.

Although the NGC thesis has not yet been addressed as part of a spatial model, its implementation in our model of blame attribution is straightforward:

$$Blame_i = \alpha|x_i - s| + \beta pid_i + \gamma|x_i - cp| + \delta|s - cp| + \varepsilon_i \quad (3)$$

where δ is the parameter that captures the effect on blame attribution of the ideological distance between the established policy position of the agent (s) and the actual policy implemented (cp). This distance represents the extent to which the policy is ideologically (in)congruent with the agent's policy reputation. The theoretical background leads us to expect δ to take a negative sign in cases of blame attribution—suggesting that voters will attribute less blame to a political agent for a failure if the adopted policy is incongruent with her long-term policy stance.

Equation 3 represents our policy-based model of blame attribution, which includes two temporally stable factors—one pertaining to the agent's policy reputation and the other to partisan identification—and two more transient factors—addressing the concrete policy adopted, and the level of ideological congruence between this policy and the agent's established policy reputation. The following section further elaborates the theoretical implications of the model and specifies its empirical predictions.

Observable Effects of the Three Policy Considerations

Assuming that the ideal position of a citizen, the established policy position of the political agent, and the concrete policy adopted are all located on one ideological axis (Adams et al. 2005; Federico 2007; Green 1988; Jost 2006), we can deduce a set of theoretical propositions. For simplicity, assume that the ideological distances between the citizen and the agent's established policy position $|x_i - s|$, and between the citizen and the implemented policy $|x_i - cp|$ can independently take either the

		AD	
		proximate ($ x_i - s = 0$)	distant ($ x_i - s = 1$)
CPD	proximate ($ x_i - cp = 0$)	(a) $\Delta p^{pid}\beta$	(b) $\alpha + \delta$
	distant ($ x_i - cp = 1$)	(c) $\Delta p^{pid}\beta + \gamma + \delta$	(d) $\alpha + \gamma$

Fig. 1 Stylized conditions implied by the model. Each cell formally presents the value of Eq. 3 for the respective condition

value of 1 (ideologically distant) or zero (proximate). Next, consider the four stylized conditions that are presented in Fig. 1: (a) The citizen is ideologically proximate to the agent's established policy position and to the actual policy ($|x_i - sl| = 0$, $|x_i - cpl| = 0$, respectively), which inevitably produces policy congruence ($|sl - cpl| = 0$); (b) the citizen is ideologically distant from the agent and proximate to the concrete policy ($|x_i - sl| = 1$, $|x_i - cpl| = 0$, respectively), and the policy is incongruent ($|sl - cpl| = 1$); (c) the citizen is ideologically proximate to the agent and distant from the policy, entailing incongruent policy; and (d) the citizen is ideologically distant from the agent and the policy, yielding congruent policy. The cells representing incongruent policy (b and c) are marked by bold frames. The equations in cells (a)–(d) represent the expected blame, based on Eq. 3. Given that the likelihood of partisan identification is associated with proximate agent distance we include the expected partisanship effect in these cells.³

This example demonstrates an interesting entailment of our theory, and holds important methodological implications. Any attempt to change one of the three factors (e.g., concrete policy distance) while holding another factor constant (e.g., agent distance = 0: moving from cell (a) to cell (c)) inescapably involves a change in the third factor (in this case: policy incongruence). Empirically, this understanding suggests that experiments that attempt to test such conditional treatments will produce *observable effects* that include more than the effect of the factor they intended to treat—a violation of the exclusion restriction (Druckman et al. 2011, p. 25).

We can derive three hypotheses from analyzing the above four stylized conditions:

H1 The observable effect of concrete policy distance is more pronounced in the case of agent non-supporters ($AD = 1$) compared to supporters ($AD = 0$).

This prediction derives from comparing the difference between the equations in cells (a) and (c): $\gamma + \delta$, to the difference between the equations in cells (b) and (d): $\gamma - \delta$, respectively. The former difference involves the assumed positive effect of increasing the concrete policy distance on blame attribution, moderated by the assumed negative (blame mitigating) effect of policy incongruence. In the latter difference, the increased concrete policy distance involves a shift to a congruent policy, thus losing the mitigating effect of policy incongruence, resulting in a pronounced observable effect of increased blame attribution.

H2 The observable effect of agent distance is more pronounced in the case of a large concrete policy distance ($CPD = 1$) compared to a proximate policy choice ($CPD = 0$).

This prediction draws on the comparison of the difference between the equations in cells (a) and (b): $\alpha + \delta - \Delta p(\beta)$, to the difference between the equations in cells (c) and (d): $\alpha - \delta - \Delta p(\beta)$, respectively. While the two changes involve the effect of increasing agent distance and a reduced likelihood of partisan identification (both

³ The probability of partisan identification under proximate agent distance is higher compared to this probability under distance agent condition: $p(pid|AD = 0) - p(pid|AD = 1) = \Delta p^{pid}$; $1 > \Delta p^{pid} > 0$.

assumed to increase blame attribution, as $\alpha > 0$, $\beta < 0$), the former change is mitigated by the effect of policy incongruence, and the latter also involves the effect of an undesired policy distance, coupled with the loss of the favorable effect of policy incongruence.

H3 The observable (negative) effect of policy incongruence on blame attribution is more pronounced (larger in absolute terms) in the case of agent non-supporters ($AD = 1$) compared to supporters ($AD = 0$).

When an ideologically proximate political agent adopts an incongruent policy (a move from cell (a) to (c)), the mitigating effect of the incongruent policy (δ) on the blame attributed to her is counteracted by the negative effect of adopting an ideologically distant policy (γ). However, when an ideologically distant agent adopts a surprising policy (a move from cell (d) to (b)), the mitigating effect of policy incongruence (δ) is joined by the effect of adopting an ideologically proximate policy ($-\gamma$). This suggests that the observable mitigating effect of policy incongruence is more pronounced for ideologically distant political agents.⁴

It should be noted that these empirical predictions—that ideological distances (from agents and policies) are particularly effective when congruent—are consistent with an alternative cognitive theory, which suggests that policy incongruence renders judgment devices such as policy and partisan cues cognitively less accessible (Huckfeldt et al. 2005). In order to empirically assess the relative efficacy of the two models, we need to disentangle the underlying factors that form the observable effects. A key to performing this analysis is the unique causal mechanism suggested by the NGC thesis according to which the effect of policy incongruence is expected to be mediated by inferred policy motivation (Cukierman and Tommasi 1998). For this purpose we included a measure of inferred policy motivation in Experiment 2 to enable us to conduct a mediation analysis for assessing which of the two causal mechanisms is better supported by the empirical results.

Experimental Design

In order to test our model of policy-based blame attribution we conducted two survey experiments. The first was fielded in Israel ($N = 402$) in September 2011, and the second in Germany ($N = 794$) in August 2013. In each experiment respondents read about one of two policy initiatives (ideologically distant/close) adopted by a particular political agent (ideologically distant/close). Since our interest is in the role of policy preferences rather than policy outcomes (e.g., Lewis-

⁴ The theoretical effects of shifting from congruent to surprising policy of proximate and distant agents are as follows: for proximate agents (a move from cell (a) to (c)): $(\Delta p^{pid} \beta + \gamma + \delta) - (\Delta p^{pid} \beta) = \gamma + \delta$; for distant agents (a move from cell (d) to (b)): $(\alpha + \delta) - (\alpha + \gamma) = \delta - \gamma$. Since we do not assume to know the sizes of γ and δ , and given that $\gamma > 0$ and $\delta < 0$, we cannot predict whether the net effect of $\gamma + \delta$ is positive or negative. We do know, however, that the net effect of $\delta - \gamma$ is negative and its absolute value is larger than the absolute value of the $\gamma + \delta$ effect. Therefore, we expect a larger reduction in blame for agent non-supporters by an additional 2γ .

Beck and Stegmaier 2000; Nannestad and Paldam 1994) in shaping blame attribution, we avoided conflating the two in estimating the effects of the three policy considerations by explicitly providing respondents with information regarding the policy outcomes. Thus, respondents in each experiment were presented with identical information regarding the (adverse) consequences of their respective policy, and completed a measure of blame attribution for their respective political agent vis-à-vis these consequences.

As described in Table 1, the two experiments vary in at least three important contextual attributes: the policy domain, the ideological axis, and the type of political agent. Beyond these deliberate differences, a wide range of social and political differences between the two experiments stem from the national and temporal context. Together, the two experiments allow us to test the predictions derived from our model.

Experiment 1: Dovish and Hawkish Policies in the Israeli–Palestinian Conflict

While in most countries the policy content of the principal axis of competition is the classical left–right axis, the central domain dividing right and left in Israel is the hawk versus dove approach to the Arab–Israeli conflict (Benoit and Laver 2006). The experiment was carried out in early September 2011, a time when a salient political issue in Israel was the Palestinian Authority’s diplomatic campaign to gain membership in the United Nations as the 194th state (known as the “State 194” campaign). While this event symbolized hope for independence for Palestinians, it was perceived as a withdrawal from the bilateral track of the peace process negotiations, and a major cause for concern and political disagreement in Israel, sparking intense public debate on the proper ways of handling the situation (Halperin et al. 2013). The experiment was fielded 2 weeks before 23 September 2011, the date President Mahmoud Abbas was scheduled to submit the application to the UN Secretary-General Ban Ki-Moon. The experiment utilizes this contested situation to present two potential Israeli policy initiatives to address the situation—one dovish and one hawkish—adopted by three different political actors in each scenario, thereby allowing both congruent and incongruent policy–agent combinations.

Table 1 The context of the two experiments

	Israeli experiment (September 2011)	German experiment (August 2013)
Policy domain	Security	Labor policy
Ideological axis	Hawk–dove	Left–right
Type of political agent	Individual political leaders	Political parties

Participants, Design, and Procedure

A nonprobability sample of 402 respondents was recruited by the Midgam Project (MP), an opt-in panel that covers the Israeli population aged 17 and older. Experiment 1 was fielded from September 6 through September 14, 2011. The sample did not include Arab respondents (20 per cent of the Israeli population) since the scenarios directly involve aspects of the Israeli–Palestinian conflict, on which Jews’ and Arabs’ attitudes systematically diverge. The MP sample approximated the Jewish population in Israel in most respects, including gender, age and education level (see Online Appendix 4). The most distinct outliers are the proportions of two categories of religiosity (over-representation of “religious” and under-representation of “traditional”). However, given that these two categories inhabit the more religious range of the religiosity scale, and their divergences counteract one another, they are not expected to seriously affect the analyses.

All respondents were first presented with a set of pre-treatment questions,⁵ followed by the treatment vignette, structured as a newspaper article (see Online Appendix 2). The article presented the background problem, the policy response, and the adverse consequences. The former and latter were held constant across all versions of the vignette, and the policy response section (the identity of the political agent and the policy adopted) varied between the experimental groups.

Policy Treatment Respondents were randomly assigned to six experimental groups (2 policies X 3 political agents) (for randomization checks cf. Online Appendix 3). The hawkish policy was a preemptive unilateral government decision to promote the annexation of the main clusters of Israeli settlements in the West Bank. The dovish policy was to take bilateral trust-building measures in order to obviate the unilateral Palestinian initiative. These measures involved the evacuation of seven Israeli settlements in the West Bank, in which a total of 1500 people resided. Both policies led to increased violence, with an identical degree of harm (see Online Appendix 2 for the full experimental vignettes).

Political Agent Treatment Each policy was presented in one of three versions, each with an alternative prime minister as the initiator of the policy. One version included Benjamin Netanyahu, a moderate hawk (Prime Minister at the time) as prime minister; the second Tzipi Livni (opposition leader at the time) as prime minister; and the third Avigdor Liberman (Foreign Minister at the time) as prime minister. Livni was chosen as the most dovish political actor with a realistic chance of becoming prime minister (as head of the party with most seats in the Knesset at the time). Liberman was chosen as the most hawkish political actor with a realistic chance of becoming prime minister (heading the second largest coalition party). The six combinations of policy and political agent are presented in Table 2. Each cell

⁵ Age, gender, country of birth, ideological self-placement, religiosity, income, vote choice in the 2009 national elections, vote intention. Religiosity plays a particularly important role in defining collective identity and political attitudes in Israeli society (Shamir and Arian 1999).

Table 2 Experimental design of Experiment 1

	Livni	Netanyahu	Liberman
Dovish policy	Congruent	Incongruent	Incongruent
Hawkish policy	Incongruent	Congruent	Congruent

presents how in/congruent the joining of the policy and political agent were designed to be.

Post-treatment Measures After reading the vignette, respondents were asked to rate the level of blame they attributed to the political actor for the consequences of the policy, and to estimate the chance that the particular political agent would have adopted this policy. The dependent variable—blame attribution—was assessed by two items. First, respondents were asked to rate the degree to which they found the prime minister responsible for the outcomes of the policy (terror attacks) on a scale of 1 (“not at all”) to 10 (“very responsible”); second, respondents were asked to state their opinion about whether the prime minister should resign due to the outcomes of the policy on a scale of 1 (“does not have to resign”) to 10 (“has to resign”). These items rely on the strong association between blame attribution and punishment-worthiness (Bartling and Fischbacher 2012; Sulitzeanu-Kenan 2006). The two items were positively correlated (Spearman’s $\rho = 0.65$, $p < 0.001$, $\alpha = 0.783$), and were thus averaged to form a measure of blame attribution that ranged from 1 to 10 ($M = 5.11$, $SD = 2.65$).

While subjecting our sample to this full-factorial design, the natural variation in respondents’ ideological positions entails that all three ideological distances were experimentally treated by randomly allocating respondents to either ideologically proximate or distant political agents and policies, as well as congruent or incongruent policies. Using each respondent’s ideological self-placement x_i on a five-scale measure,⁶ and based on the experimental condition assigned to her, we calculated two variables that indicate the respondent’s ideological distance from the agent’s position ($|x_i - sl|$) and from the concrete policy ($|x_i - cpl|$). The agent’s established position (s) was set as 1 for respondents that were assigned to a hawkish prime minister (Netanyahu and Liberman) and as 0 in the case of the dovish prime minister (Livni).⁷

A dummy variable denoting incongruent policy takes the value 1 in the three experimental conditions that present an incongruent policy (e.g., a hawkish prime minister and a dovish policy), and zero in the three congruent policy conditions, as

⁶ The ideological self-placement scale ranges from 1 (extreme hawk) to 5 (extreme dove). It was subsequently reversed and set to range from 0 (extreme dove) to 1 (extreme hawk).

⁷ We assessed the robustness of the results in less extreme agent and policy ideological placements. Agent and concrete policy distance effects retain a relatively stable mean effect across agent/policy extremity levels, but the variances of these effects become large at less extreme levels. These results are provided in Online Appendix 6.

presented in Table 2.⁸ Finally, a dummy variable indicating partisan identity takes the value 1 for respondents who reported (pre-treatment) voting for the party of the agent they were assigned, and zero otherwise.

Experiment 2: Labor Market Regulation in Germany

An important difference between Israel and Germany for the purpose of this research is the principal dimension of political competition. While in Israel it centers on national security, in Germany it is focused on socio-economic issues (Benoit and Laver 2006). Therefore, we concentrated on labor market regulation as one of the more salient issues in German economic policy in recent years (Zohlnhöfer 2014). Another relevant difference between the two countries is the level of personalization of politics. While Israel represents a case of high personalization, this is not the case in Germany (Rahat and Sheaffer 2007), leading us to choose individual politicians as agents in the Israeli experiment, and parties as agents in the German experiment. The timing of the experiment—less than two months before the 2013 general election—utilized a situation in which respondents could consider different party coalitions as potentially feasible (nonetheless, with varying probabilities) in the short term.

The regulation of the German labor market has been discussed since the mid-1980 s. Although the main parties performed some twists and turns regarding their policy positions on the issue, the long-term policy stance of the Christian Democrats (CDU/CSU) and the Liberals (FDP) was in favor of labor market liberalization and against a minimum-wage while the Social Democrats (SPD) and the Greens favored a stricter regulation of the labor market and (more recently) a general minimum wage.

Participants, Design, and Procedure

A nonprobability sample of 1510 respondents was recruited by Bamberg Center for Empirical Studies (BACES), an opt-in panel that covers the German population aged 15 years and older. Experiment 2 was fielded from July 25 through August 19, 2013. After excluding respondents who failed an instructional manipulation check (IMC) (Oppenheimer et al. 2009) the sample that was used in the analyses consisted of 794 respondents.

The BACES sample approximates the German population in most respects, including gender, age, voting intentions, and political knowledge. The outlier, as in many Internet samples, is the proportion of people who report having post-high-school education. However, while respondents in Experiment 2 are slightly more educated, they do not demonstrate greater political knowledge (for details see Online Appendix 4).

⁸ Successful manipulation of policy in/congruence was verified (for details see Online Appendix 5).

Table 3 Experimental design of Experiment 2

	CDU/CSU and FDP	SPD and Greens
Right policy (liberalization)	Congruent	Incongruent
Left policy (minimum wage)	Incongruent	Congruent

As in Experiment 1, all respondents were first presented with a set of pre-treatment questions,⁹ followed by the treatment vignette, structured as a newspaper article (see Online Appendix 2). The article presented the background problem, the policy response, and the adverse consequences. The former and latter were held constant across all versions of the vignette, and the policy response section varied between the experimental groups.

Policy Treatment Respondents were randomly assigned to four experimental groups (2 policies X 2 government coalitions) (for randomization checks cf. Online Appendix 3). The right-wing policy represented a substantial liberalization of employment protection, and the left-wing policy included the introduction of a comparatively high general minimum wage. Both policies, as described in the vignettes, led to an identical negative outcome, namely a substantial increase in unemployment (caused by the respective measures according to a fictitious expert in the vignettes) (see Online Appendix 2 for full experimental vignettes).

Political Agent Treatment Each policy appeared in one of two versions. One version presented a near political future in which a CDU/CSU and FDP coalition government has been established and the second in which a SPD and Greens coalition government rules. The four combinations of policy and government coalition are presented in Table 3. Each cell presents how in/congruent the joining of the policy and government coalition is designed to be.

Post-treatment Measures After reading the vignette, respondents were asked to rate the level of blame they attributed to the relevant coalition parties for the policy outcome, and to estimate the likelihood that the respective coalition (in their vignette) would have actually adopted the particular reform. The dependent variable—blame attribution—was assessed by three items. First, respondents were asked to rate the degree to which they found the party in question responsible for the outcomes on a scale from 1 (“not at all”) to 10 (“very responsible”); second, respondents were asked to state the extent to which they thought that the relevant minister should resign given the consequences of the policy on a scale from 1 (“does not have to resign”) to 10 (“has to resign”); and third, respondents reported the degree to which they felt anger toward the party in question for the outcome of the policy. This measurement scale was found to be internally consistent ($\alpha = 0.88$),

⁹ Age, gender, education, ideological self-placement, intention to vote, vote choice, political interest, political knowledge.

and the three items were averaged to form a measure of blame attribution that ranged from 1 to 10 ($M = 6.09$, $SD = 2.67$).

Since the experimental treatments relied on textual vignettes, our questionnaire in Experiment 2 included an instructional manipulation check (IMC) (Oppenheimer et al. 2009). The IMC is a single-item tool for detecting respondents who are not following textual instructions, or satisfies in reading and answering survey questions. 794 respondents cleared the IMC question (52.65%), and the rest of the analyses were conducted with this sub-sample. It should be noted that attempting to predict IMC clearing using logistic regression with the experimental conditions represented by a set of three dummy variables yielded an insignificant model ($N = 1508$, LR $\chi^2 = 1.28$, $p = 0.733$), and none of the coefficients were statistically significant.

As in Experiment 1, all three ideological distances were experimentally treated by randomly assigning respondents to either ideologically proximate or distant political agents and policies, and either congruent or incongruent policy situation. As in Experiment 1, we used each respondent's ideological self-placement x_i ($0 = \text{left}$, $1 = \text{right}$)¹⁰ and, based on the experimental condition assigned to her, calculated the respondent's ideological distance from the agent's position ($|x_i - sl|$) and from the policy's position ($|x_i - cpl|$). The agent's established position (s) was set as 1 for respondents that were assigned to a right-wing coalition (CDU/CSU and FDP) and as 0 in the case of a left-wing coalition (SPD and Greens).¹¹

A dummy variable denoting incongruent policy takes the value 1 in the two experimental conditions involving incongruent policy (e.g., right-wing coalition and left-wing policy), and zero in the two congruent policy conditions, as presented in Table 2. A dummy variable indicating partisan identity takes the value 1 for respondents who reported (pre-treatment) voting for either of the two parties included in the coalition they were assigned, and zero otherwise. Finally, in Experiment 2 we included a measure of *inferred policy motivation* for the purpose of testing its mediating role in transmitting the effect of incongruent policy on blame attribution. Respondents were asked to choose one of two possible motivations that they believed accounted for the policy choice in their respective vignette. The two options were that 'this policy fulfills the party's ideological beliefs' (coded as 1) or that 'this policy was seen as the best way to address the economic situation' (coded as 0).

¹⁰ The ideological self-placement scale was based on a slider which respondents were able to locate on a line between "left" and "right". The position of the slider was recorded as a figure between 1 (left) and 33 (right). For the purpose of the analyses, it was set to range from 0 (left) to 1 (right).

¹¹ As in the Israeli experiment, we assessed the robustness of the results in less extreme agent and policy ideological placements. Agent and concrete policy distance effects retain a relatively stable mean effect across agent/policy extremity levels, except from the very moderate level (0.4/0.6). These results are provided in Online Appendix 6.

Results

Our empirical analyses include three elements. We initially estimate each of the three policy-based factors and the partisan identification effect based on data from the two experiments. Next, we test the three hypotheses that the interactions among the three policy considerations entail. Lastly, we employ causal mediation analysis to assess the causal mechanism predicted by our model.

Estimating the Model's Four Factors

We estimate the effects of the four factors of the model on the level of blame attributed to the political agents in the two experiments, using OLS regressions. Tabular results for the two regression models (one for each of the experiments) are provided in Online Appendix 7 (Table A3), and are presented in graphical form in Fig. 2.

In line with the model's predictions, regression results for both experiments indicate positive effects of agent-distance ($lx_i - sl$) and of policy distance ($lx_i - cpl$) on blame attribution, a negative effect of party identification, and a negative effect of policy-incongruence.¹² In the following discussion of the results we will refer to standardized coefficients in order to facilitate the assessment of the relative weight of each factor to the subsequent evaluation. Respondents who were assigned to evaluate political agents that were ideologically distant from their ideological position, attributed more blame ($\alpha_{IL} = 0.113$, $p = 0.035$; $\alpha_{DE} = 0.117$, $p < 0.001$; one-tailed) to their respective agents for the adverse outcome, regardless of the policy that led to this outcome (and beyond the effect of partisanship). Similarly, respondents who were presented with concrete policies that were ideologically distant from their ideological position attributed greater blame to their respective political agent ($\delta_{IL} = 0.269$, $p < 0.001$; $\delta_{DE} = 0.092$, $p = 0.002$) regardless of the latter's ideological distance. In line with previous studies (Rudolph 2006; Tilley and Hobolt 2011), respondents who identified with their respective agent's parties attributed less blame ($\beta_{IL} = -0.201$, $p < 0.001$; $\beta_{DE} = -0.239$, $p < 0.001$). Lastly, in both experiments respondents assigned less blame to their respective political agents in incongruent agent-policy situations ($\theta_{IL} = -0.082$, $p = 0.088$; $\theta_{DE} = -0.055$, $p = 0.055$).

These results provide consistent support for the suggested model. They are in line with studies that report joint effects of partisan identification and (concrete) policy information on levels of support (Boudreau and MacKenzie 2014; Bullock 2011; Carsey and Layman 2006). Yet our findings also show that an agent's established policy reputation continues to guide the evaluations of political agents alongside recent policy information. Lastly, the relationship between stable policy

¹² Given that both experiments were conducted in multi-party systems, partisanship and agent-distance were not expected to be overly correlated. Indeed multicollinearity is not an issue in both of the experiments (Israel: agent-distance VIF = 1.42, partisanship VIF = 1.15, mean VIF = 1.33; Germany: agent-distance VIF = 1.26, partisanship VIF = 1.11, mean VIF = 1.10).

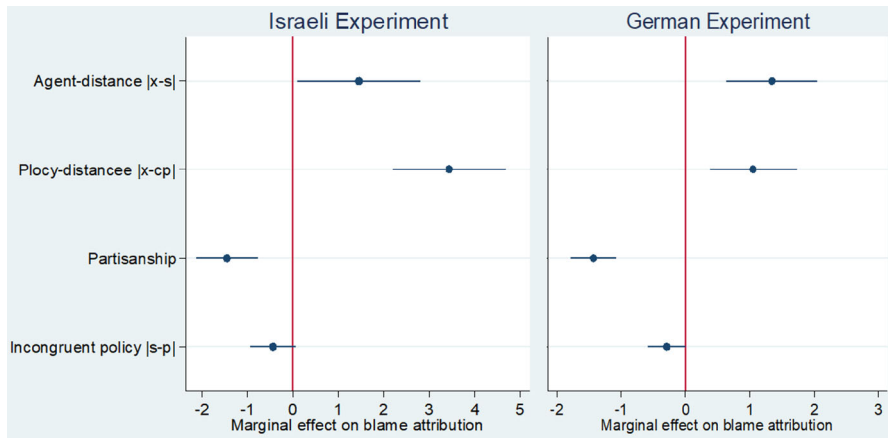


Fig. 2 Point estimates and 95% confidence intervals of the four factors' coefficients. These analyses control for the identity of the Prime Minister, policy-orientation (L/R), respondent's ideological self-placement, and income (IL); and for the identity of the coalition, policy-orientation (L/R), respondent's ideological self-placement, and education level (DE). The coefficients for agent and policy distance represent the change in blame attributed when moving from one end of the ideological spectrum to the other

expectations and an actual policy choice carries its own effect on blame attribution, in line with the NGC thesis.

Testing the Three Observable Predictions Entailed by the Interactions Among the Policy Considerations

To test hypotheses 1–3, we collapsed our continuous agent and policy distance variables into dummy variables representing ideologically proximate and distant agent/policy.¹³ In order to test hypotheses one and two in both experiments we estimated the level of blame attribution by using the interaction between agent distance and policy distance, while controlling for partisan identification, the identity of the political agent (prime minister in Israel, and coalition in Germany),

¹³ In the Israeli experiments respondents were coded as evaluating an ideologically distant agent (AD = 1) if they identified as “extreme hawk” or “hawk” and the political agent was Livni, or if they identified as “center”, “dove” or “extreme dove” and the policy agent was Netanyahu or Liberman. They were coded as evaluating an ideologically proximate agent (AD = 0) otherwise. Respondents were coded as evaluating a large policy-distance (CPD = 1) if they identified as “extreme hawk” or “hawk” and the policy was dovish, or if they identified as “center”, “dove” or “extreme dove” and the policy was hawkish. They were coded as evaluating an ideologically proximate policy (CPD = 0) otherwise (the results also hold when coding those identified as “center” as “hawks”). In the German experiment respondents were coded as evaluating an ideologically distant agent (AD = 1) if their ideological measure was less than 15 (median) and the political agent was a CDU/CSU and FDP coalition, or if their ideological measure was 15 or higher and the political agent was a SPD and Greens coalition. They were coded as evaluating an ideologically proximate agent (AD = 0) otherwise. Respondents were coded as evaluating an ideologically distant policy (CPD = 1) if their ideological measure was less than 15 and the policy was labor-market liberalization; or if their ideological measure was 15 or higher and the policy was minimum wage. They were coded as evaluating a proximate policy (CPD = 0) otherwise.

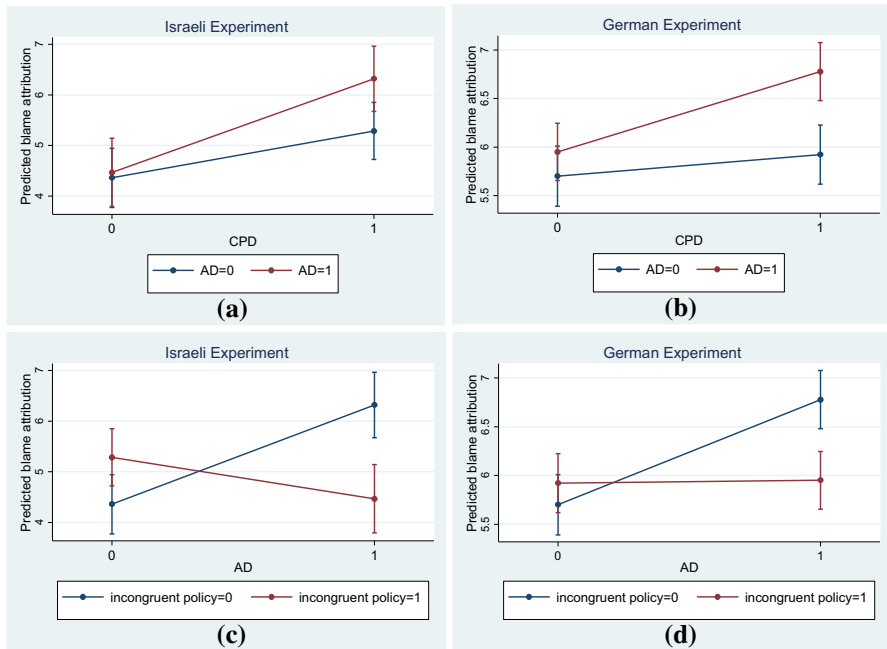


Fig. 3 **a, b** The conditional effects of agent distance and policy distance on the mean level of blame attribution (Y-axis) in Israel and Germany, respectively (H1 and H2). **c, d** The conditional effects of incongruent policy on the mean level of blame attribution in Israel and Germany, respectively (H3)

the policy (right/hawk–left/dove), and individual covariates (income in Israel, and education level in Germany):

$$E(RA_i | (AD, CPD, X)_i) = C + \omega_1 AD_i + \omega_2 CPD_i + \omega_3 AD_i * CPD_i + \beta pid_i + \omega_4 agent + \omega_5 policy + \omega_6 covariates_i + \varepsilon_i \quad (4)$$

where the observed effect of agent distance under proximate concrete policy is represented by ω_1 , the observed effect of concrete policy distance under an ideologically proximate agent is represented by ω_2 , the observed effect of agent ideological distance under ideologically distant concrete policy is represented by $\omega_1 + \omega_3$, and the observed effect of policy distance under an ideologically distant agent is represented by $\omega_2 + \omega_3$.

We report detailed results for Experiments 1 and 2 in tabular form in Online Appendix 7 and in graphical form in Fig. 3. As can be seen in Figs. 3a, b, the interaction between the agent and policy distances is marginally significant in the Israeli experiment ($p = 0.078$) and statistically significant in the German experiment ($p = 0.047$). Figure 3c, d graphically demonstrate that the interaction between agent distance and policy incongruence is statistically significant in both experiments ($p < 0.001$ and $p = 0.001$, respectively). Table 4 presents detailed results for each of the three hypotheses (for detailed explanations see Online Appendix 7).

Table 4 Hypotheses testing results

	Israeli experiment	German experiment
H1	The effect of CPD is small and marginally statistically significant under a proximate agent (0.928, $p = 0.078$), and is larger and statistically significant under an ideologically distant agent (1.847, $p < 0.001$)—see Fig. 3a	The effect of CPD is small and statistically insignificant under a proximate agent (0.222, $p = 0.621$), and is larger and statistically significant under an ideologically distant agent (0.827, $p < 0.001$)—see Fig. 3b
H2	The effect of AD is small and statistically insignificant under a proximate policy (0.109, $p = 0.999$), and is larger and statistically significant under an ideologically distant policy (1.028, $p < 0.041$)—see Fig. 3a	The effect of AD is small and statistically insignificant under a proximate policy (0.250, $p = 0.512$), and is larger and statistically significant under an ideologically distant policy (0.856, $p < 0.001$)—see Fig. 3b
H3	The effect of policy incongruence is positive and marginally significant under an ideologically proximate agent (0.928, $p = 0.078$), and is larger, negative and statistically significant under an ideologically distant agent (− 1.847, $p < 0.001$)—see Fig. 3c	The effect of policy incongruence is positive and statistically insignificant under an ideologically proximate agent (0.222, $p = 0.621$), and is larger, negative and statistically significant under an ideologically distant agent (− 0.827, $p < 0.001$)—see Fig. 3d

Note All post hoc tests were Bonferroni corrected

These results provide consistent support for the three hypotheses across the two experiments.

As predicted by our model, the observable positive effect of agent distance on blame attribution is larger when the policy adopted by the agent is ideologically distant; the observable positive effect of concrete policy distance on blame attribution is more pronounced when the adopting agent is ideologically distant; and the mitigating effect of policy incongruence is observable only when the evaluated agent is ideologically distant.

Causal Mechanism

While our model's predictions are consistent with the finding that ideological distances (from agents and concrete policies) are particularly effective when congruent, the question remains whether the causal mechanism provided by our model accounts for these results. The key question is whether the effect of policy incongruence joins the effects of agent and policy distance under conditions of incongruent policy, resulting in a weakened combined effect—as our model predicts—or whether judgment devices such as policy cues become cognitively less accessible under incongruent policy conditions, and thus lose their potency—as Huckfeldt et al. (2005) suggest. To answer this question we require a unique empirical marker of the policy incongruence effect that would enable us to identify it when it is joined by another policy consideration effect.

The particular causal mechanism suggested by the NGC theory potentially offers such an empirical marker. According to the theory, the effect of policy

Table 5 Causal mediation analyses

	Policy incongruence	Agent distance	Concrete policy distance
Mediation effect	– 0.145	0.016	0.015
95% CI	[– 0.243, – 0.058]	[– 0.021, 0.061]	[– 0.023, 0.060]
Direct effect	– 0.161	0.499	0.557
	[– 0.473, 0.146]	[0.167, 0.819]	[0.258, 0.851]
Total effect	– 0.306	0.514	0.572
	[– 0.613, – 0.008]	[0.190, 0.835]	[0.272, 0.871]
Conditional effects			
	CPD = 0	CPD = 1	AD = 0
Mediation effect	– 0.136	0.077	– 0.099
95% CI	[– 0.283 to – 0.033]	[– 0.061 to 0.219]	[– 0.234 to – 0.005]
Direct effect	0.346	0.777	0.379
	[– 0.124 to 0.803]	[0.316–1.225]	[– 0.065 to 0.809]
Total effect	0.210	0.853	0.279
	[– 0.238 to 0.655]	[0.411–1.284]	[– 0.154 to 0.694]

Note Model specification: Mediation effects were calculated using algorithm in Hicks and Tingley (2011). Coefficients in bold indicate $p < 0.05$, based on a two-tailed test. Treatments are policy incongruence, agent distance, and policy distance. Mediator is inferred policy motivation

incongruence is mediated by inferred policy motivation (Cukierman and Tommasi 1998). If this mediation process is empirically identified in the effect of policy incongruence, but is *not* found for the two other policy considerations (agent and concrete policy distances), we can use this mediating factor to disentangle the observable effects, and assess which of the two competing theoretical explanations—cognitive organization (Huckfeldt et al. 2005) or the one suggested by our model—provide a better account of the findings. As noted above, a measure of inferred policy motivation was included in our post-treatment measures in the German experiment, as a possible mediator.

Table 5 presents the results of causal mediation analyses (Imai et al. 2011), which compute the average causal mediation effect (ACME), i.e., the expected change in blame attribution when the mediator (inferred policy motivation) takes the value it would realize under the treatment condition (policy incongruences, distant agent or distant policy) as opposed to the control condition (policy congruence, proximate agent or proximate policy, respectively), while the treatment status is held constant. Causal mediation was implemented via the mediation package in Stata (Hicks and Tingley 2011). To satisfy the sequential ignorability assumption (Imai et al. 2011), we include pretreatment controls (gender, age, education, and ideology) that may be related to both the outcome (blame attribution) and the mediator (inferred policy motivation).

The upper half of Table 5 demonstrates that the treatment condition of policy incongruence led respondents to decrease blame attribution by increasing their tendency to infer that the policy was adopted for pragmatic (rather than ideological) reasons. The mediated effect of policy incongruence is negative and statistically significant (-0.145 ; $p < 0.01$), and this causal pathway is estimated to account for 46% of the total effect. These results provide support for the proposition made by Cukierman and Tommasi (1998) that policy incongruence is mediated by inferred policy motivation. On the other hand, inferred policy motivation does not appear to mediate the effect of either agent or policy distance, as reflected by the small and statistically insignificant mediation effects for these treatments (top of the middle and right columns in Table 5). These results enable us to use the mediated effect of inferred policy motivation as an empirical marker of the policy incongruence effect, and thus test whether this effect plays a role in moderating the conditional effects of agent and policy distances.

The bottom half of Table 5 demonstrates that the conditional effects of both agent and policy distances are mediated by the tendency to infer that the policy was adopted for pragmatic reasons (unlike their respective main effects), indicating the involvement of policy incongruence in these conditional treatments. Moreover, these mediated effects are negative (diminishing blame attribution) where the treatment involves a change to incongruent policy, and are positive where the treatment involves a change to congruent policy. These results support the causal mechanism suggested by our model, by demonstrating that policy incongruence is an integral and inseparable part of the model, and are less compatible with the cognitive organization argument (Huckfeldt et al. 2005).

Discussion

This paper proposes a policy-based model of blame attribution, by extending the theoretical understanding of the role of policy considerations into the study of political blame. Combining previous findings regarding the role of partisanship in shaping blame attribution with insights from spatial models, we take three theoretical steps: (1) apply an established measure of ideological distance between the evaluating individual and the agent's established policy position to the model of responsibility attribution; (2) introduce a factor that pertains to a concrete policy adopted by an agent (without discarding the original factor regarding the established policy position of the agent); (3) add a factor that captures the level of (in)congruence between the expected and actual policy. The latter factor relies on the 'Nixon-goes-to-China' thesis, as well as social-psychological findings on responsibility attribution. These three policy-based factors, together with partisan identity are formally incorporated in our model. The logical relationship between the three policy-oriented factors entails unique observable predictions, which in turn revise both the current literature on elite and policy information effects, and the 'Nixon-goes-to-China' thesis.

The policy-based model of blame attribution was consistently supported by the results of two survey experiments, conducted in Israel and Germany. These consistent results were obtained despite strong contextual variation in the ideological axes (hawk–dove and right–left), policy context (security and labor policy), and type of political agents (individual politicians and party-coalitions) in the two experiments. Our findings go beyond the almost exclusive focus on economic policy, and include handling of an international conflict as a policy domain (in the Israeli experiment).

The ability of the policy-based model to account for differences in blame attribution raises the question whether our model may also account for other political judgments. For example, can the three policy considerations similarly account for the level of political *support* for agents and policies? Note that applying our model to such positive political evaluations requires reversing the signs for all three factor coefficients (as well as partisanship). Citizens who are ideologically distant from the agent's long-term policy stance will be *less* supportive of the agent than citizens who hold policy preferences that are closer to the agent's established policy position; therefore, α , the effect of agent distance, is expected to be negative; citizens who like the concrete policy are more likely to support the initiative, therefore, γ , representing the effect of concrete policy distance, is assumed to be negative; lastly, we assume that parties that adopt policies that are unlikely based on their established policy reputations will be rewarded and δ as the parameter that captures the effect of policy incongruence, should therefore be positive.

Although a comprehensive test of the model's applicability to other political judgments is beyond the scope of this paper, we reviewed the results of four existing experimental studies whose design is adequate for evaluating the utility of our policy-based model beyond blame attribution—two laboratory experiments (Cohen

2003; Huckfeldt et al. 2005) and two survey experiments (Ditto and Mastronarde 2009; Nicholson 2011).

Cohen (2003) and Nicholson (2011) both look at welfare state expansion and retrenchment in the context of the US two-party system. Cohen's (2003) is one of the more notable studies that have found a dominance of party cues (i.e. party identification) over policy information (i.e. concrete policy distance). Our re-analysis of the available results (Cohen's study 1) indeed provides no support for the effect of concrete policy distance, along with an exceptionally large and positive effect of partisanship. More importantly, we do find supports in Cohen's results for the existence of a positive policy incongruence effect (see Online Appendix 8).

Nicholson (2011), who replicated Cohen's study within a survey experiment, did find support for both policy and party cues. Applying our model to his results provides further support for a policy incongruence effect. Moreover, in line with the predictions of our model, the observable effect of policy distance appears to be more pronounced in the case of agent non-party supporters compared to supporters, for both Democrats and Republicans; and the effect of agent distance is more pronounced in the case of a large concrete policy distance compared to a proximate policy distance for both Democrats and Republicans (see online Appendix 9). Interestingly, in his article Nicholson acknowledges these varying effects, and offers a tentative explanation that is quite similar to the logic of the "Nixon goes to China" thesis:

Democratic identifiers might be more persuaded because the Democratic Party is taking a position counter to its reputation as the party of the working class (Nicholson and Segura 2012). As such, the Democratic Party might be *perceived as more trustworthy or credible*. Although it is not entirely clear what the mechanism is behind the effect, it is clearly unexpected for the Democratic Party to back a stringent welfare policy (Nicholson 2011, pp. 9–10, italics added).

These findings, to which Nicholson offers a tentative explanation, are directly predicted and comprehensively explained by the policy model suggested here.

In addition, in an experimental study of attitudes regarding political mavericks (politicians who cross party lines to "vote their conscience"), Ditto and Mastronarde (2009) have found that such politicians are judged more favorably only when they are members of the opposing party of the evaluating respondent. This finding is in line with the third observable prediction of our model (H3).

Finally, we have already shown in "[Causal Mechanism](#)" section that our model accounts for the findings of Huckfeldt et al. (2005), while requiring no unique assumptions regarding the cognitive ability to process information under conditions of incongruence between an agent's policy reputation and her concrete policy.

It thus appears that the policy model is consistent with the results of existing studies of political support; it provides explanation to some unexpected findings in one case (Nicholson 2011); and in line with Occam's razor, offers an explanation that requires less stringent assumptions in another (Huckfeldt et al. 2005). Additionally, the apparent applicability of the model to the results of studies that utilized positive evaluations as their dependent variable, in a two-party system,

demonstrates its external validity beyond the context of blame attribution and multi-party systems.

The policy-based model of blame joins the existing strand of the literature which focuses on individual-level explanations of responsibility attribution in politics, and explicitly incorporates partisanship in its parameters. However, it draws attention to the fact that policy preferences can relate to the established policy reputation of an evaluated political agent, but also to the concrete policy choice she adopts. This distinction between the identity of the evaluated, and her acts, in attributing responsibility has been missing from most of the existing studies on this topic. Lastly, the relationship between policy reputation and the concrete policy choice—the extent to which the policy adopted is surprising—serves as a signal for the agent’s motivation in adopting the policy, which forms an additional consideration in the formation of blame judgments. By identifying the three simultaneous channels in which policy preferences play a role—vis-à-vis the agent’s established policy reputation, the concrete policy choice, and the congruence among the two—we have shown that policy preferences exert three *stable* effects, the *sum* of which varies, depending on their particular superposition. This understanding is explicitly specified in the formal model, and is supported by the experimental results, and mediation analyses. Importantly, this research formally and empirically shows that the three policy-oriented factors are inescapably intertwined, requiring a theoretical model that integrates individual-level (partisanship and policy preferences) and macro-level (policy reputations and policy content) data in the study of political responsibility.

The finding that policy preferences play a role in shaping blame attribution, poses new questions that are beyond the scope of the current article. For example an ongoing debate exists in the literature between proponents of the ‘selective evaluation’ model who contend that partisanship mainly affects performance evaluations (C. J. Anderson et al. 2004; Ladner and Wlezien 2007), and advocates of the ‘selective attribution’ model who posit that it primarily conditions attribution of responsibility (Pettigrew 1979; Rudolph 2003b; Rudolph and Grant 2002; Tilley and Hobolt 2011). In the same vein we may now ask whether the effects of agent distance, concrete policy distance and policy congruence mainly shape performance evaluations, or attribution of responsibility for these evaluations. These questions may serve as potential lines of inquiry of future studies.

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